SLATE CITATION LAB · RESEARCH REPORT

We asked ChatGPT, Perplexity, Claude and Gemini the same 1,000 B2B software questions.

They agreed on 29 sources. Out of 31,128.

ChatGPT · Perplexity · Claude · Gemini · + Google AI Overview

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9 findings on how AI engines actually pick sources

31,128 citations · **11,002** pages scraped · **19** page attributes tested

Shiyam Sunder · CEO, Slate

swipe →

METHOD

How we ran it.

01

QUERIES

1,000 B2B SaaS questions

40 categories · 28 intent types
334 BOFU · 333 MOFU · 333 TOFU

↓

02

ENGINES

4 engines, web search on

gpt-5.4-mini · sonar-pro
claude-sonnet-4.6 · gemini-2.5-flash

↓

03

EXTRACTION

Every URL, normalised

host lowercased · www + trailing slash stripped
20 tracking params removed (utm_*, gclid…)

↓

04

JOIN

Matched to Google, per query

7,878 top-10 pages · 9,418 AI Overview citations
11,002-page attribute scrape

↓

05

STATS

Effect sizes, not vibes

Mann-Whitney + Cliff's δ · χ^2 + φ
logistic models with rank as a control

READ WITH CARE

- API, not the consumer apps. UI and API retrieve differently.
- One run per query, one date. Decimals won't last; gaps this big will.
- Gemini's grounding data sits outside the answer text and wasn't captured.
- 61 Claude answers were truncated, so Claude's counts are a floor.

FINDING 01 · LINK VOLUME

One engine shows 19 sources per answer. Another shows almost none.

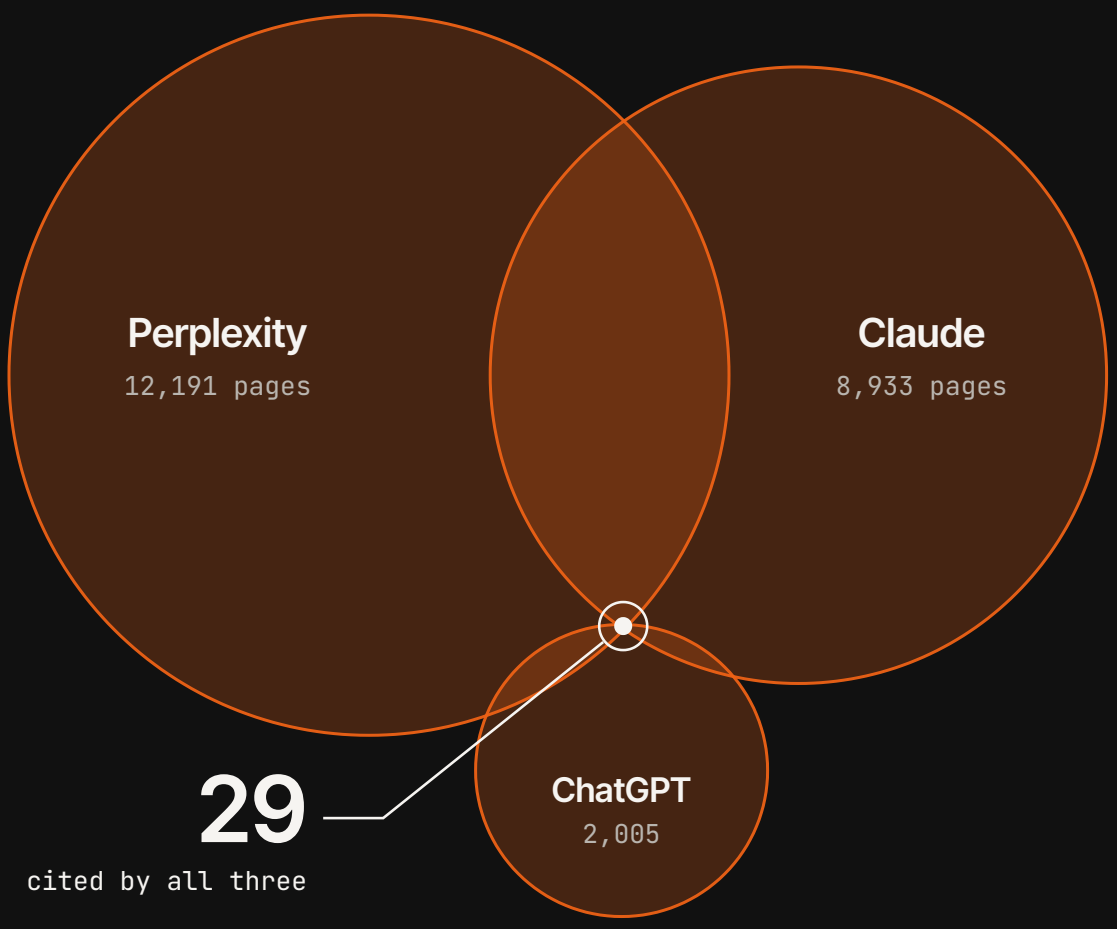
	SOURCE LINKS PER ANSWER · each block = 1 link	ANSWERS WITH ≥1 LINK
Perplexity	19.08	100%
Claude	12.49	97.8%
Google AI Overview	9.42	95.9%
ChatGPT	3.10	62.8%
Gemini*	0.07	1.6%

* Gemini: 16 of 1,000 captured answers contained a URL. Its grounding metadata is returned outside the answer text.

→ Citation is a product decision, not a shared feature. "AI citation rate" is not one number.

FINDING 02 · SOURCES

Same question, same day. Almost no shared sources.



URL OVERLAP PER QUERY

Perplexity · Claude	13.6%
ChatGPT · Perplexity	0.9%
ChatGPT · Claude	0.5%

WHO CITED EACH QUERY-URL PAIR

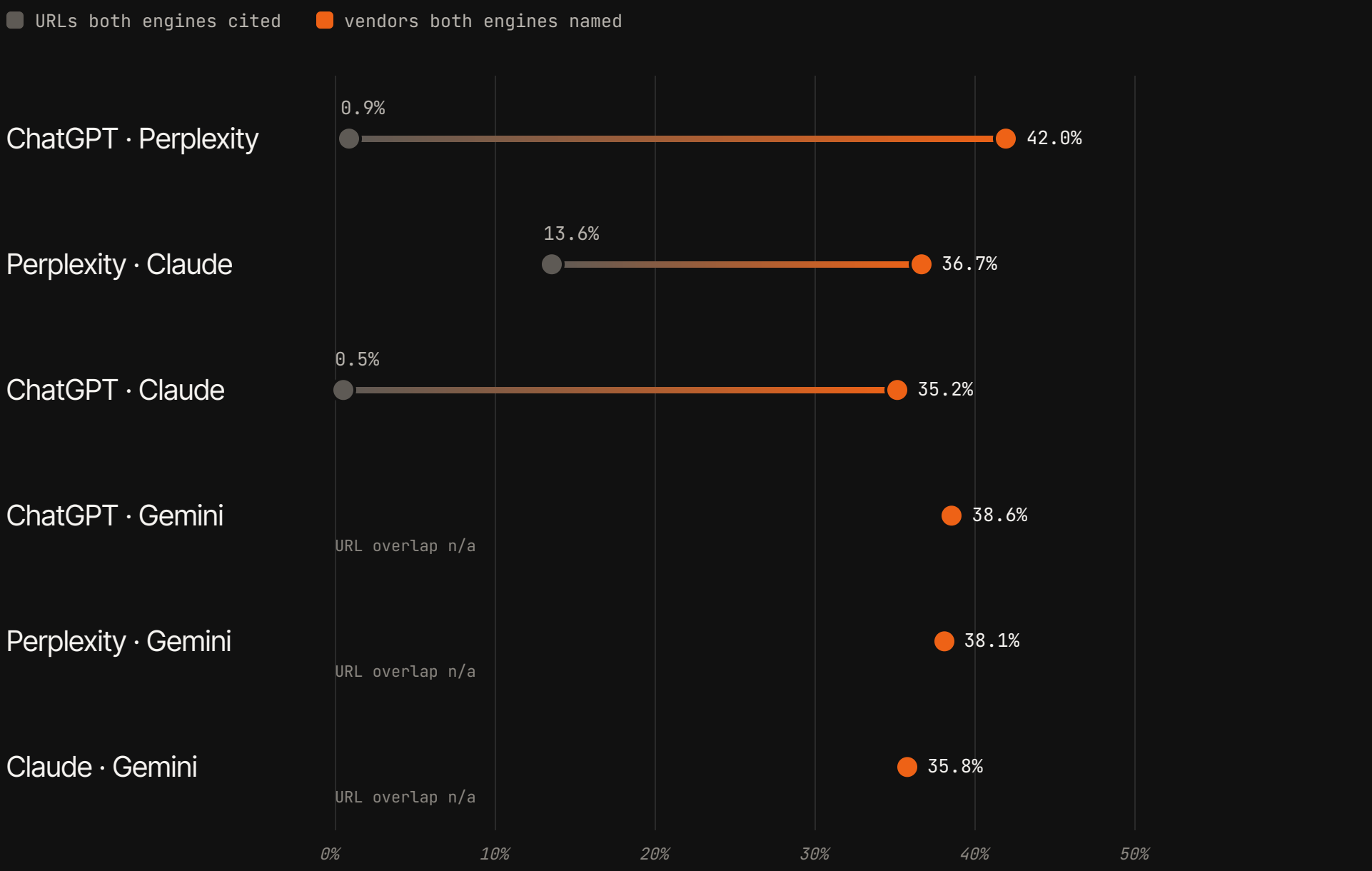
one engine only	88.7%
two engines	11.2%
all three	0.09%

When all three agree, 62.1% of the time it's already a Google top-10 page.
Circle area = unique pages each engine cited.

→ Winning a citation in one engine transfers almost nothing to the next.

FINDING 03 · VENDORS

Different evidence. Same shortlist.



509
queries where all four engines named at least one vendor

7.5
vendors named across the four engines, per query

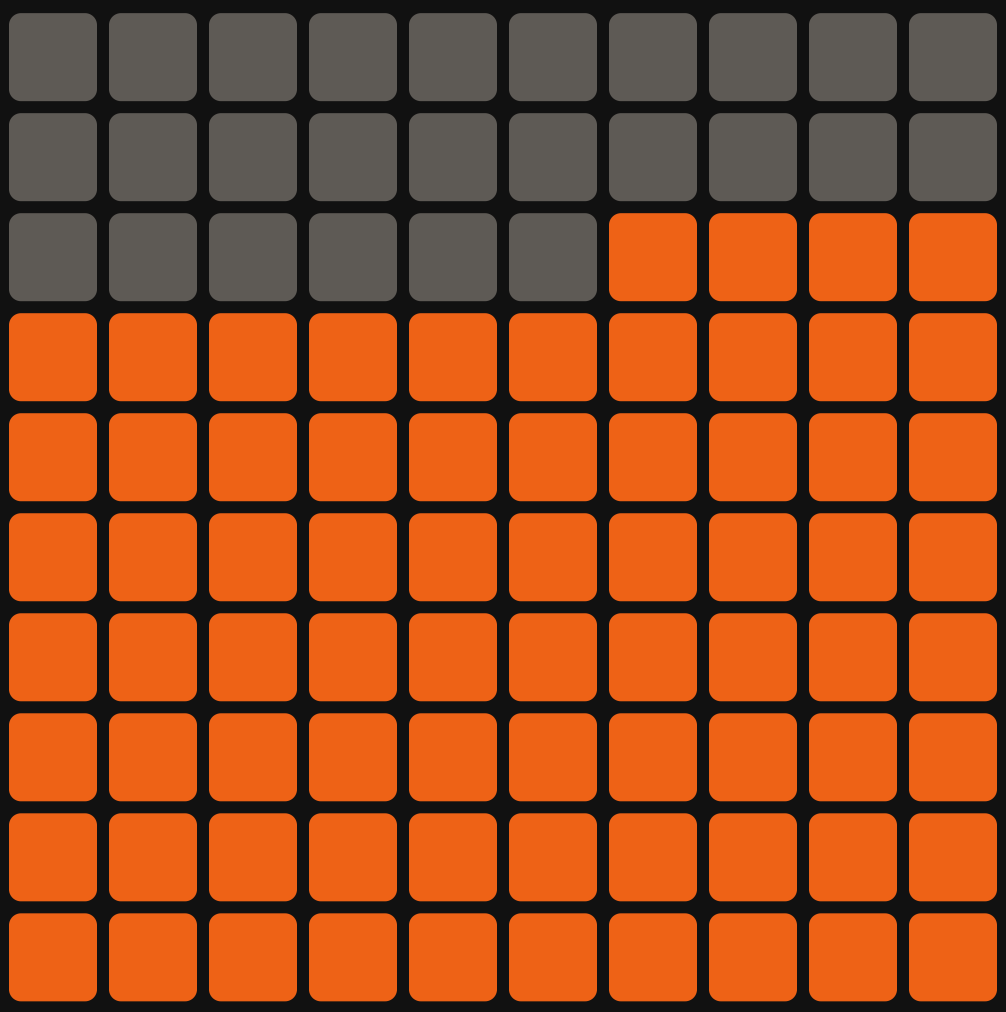
2.1
vendors named by all four

154 curated B2B SaaS brands, capitalised whole-word match, common-word brand names excluded.

→ Getting named is one game across every engine. Getting cited is four separate ones.

FINDING 04 · THE INVISIBLE POOL

74% of what AI cites isn't in Google's results at all.



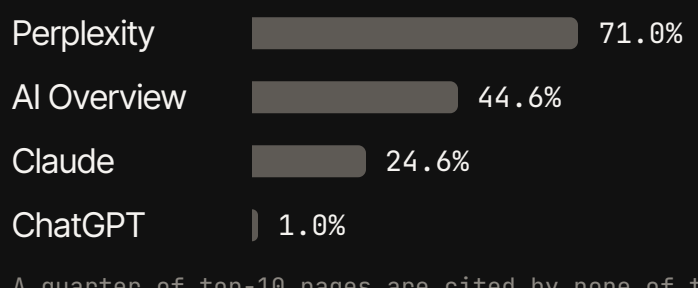
cited, not in Google top 10 or AI Overview

cited and in Google's data

14,757

of 19,906 unique cited URLs appear in neither Google's top 10 nor the AI Overview.

SHARE OF GOOGLE'S 7,878 TOP-10 PAGES EACH ENGINE QUOTES



A quarter of top-10 pages are cited by none of the three link-showing engines.

→ If your AI visibility report is built on rank tracking, it sees about a quarter of where you are quoted.

FINDING 05 · THE REDDIT DIVIDE

546 forum pages ranked on page one. Claude quoted none of them.

Each dot = one Reddit, Quora or Stack Overflow page in Google's top 10 for these queries.



REDDIT.COM CITATIONS ACROSS ALL 1,000 ANSWERS

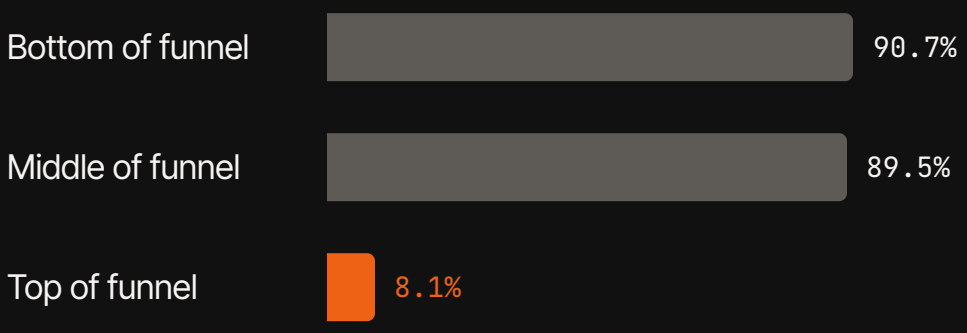
1,051	243	0	0
Perplexity	AI Overview	ChatGPT	Claude

→ Reddit is Perplexity's #1 domain. For ChatGPT and Claude, Reddit seeding bought zero citations.

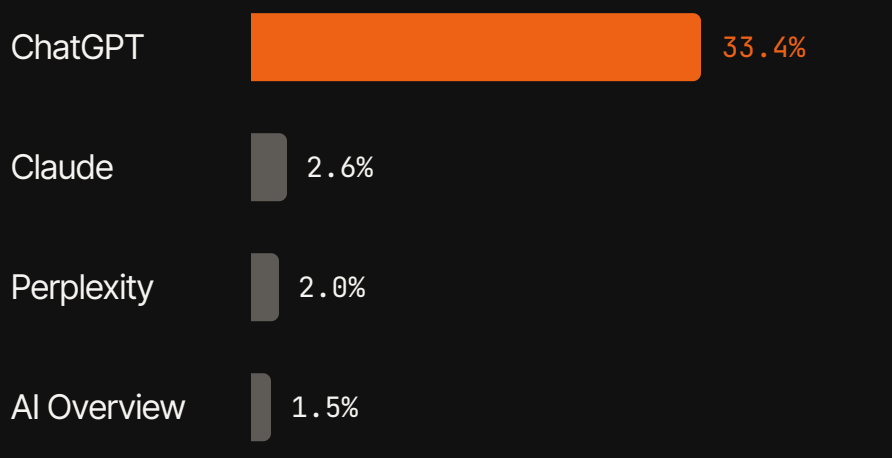
FINDING 06 · CHATGPT

ChatGPT isn't citing sources. It's linking products.

QUERIES WHERE CHATGPT SHOWED ANY LINK



LINKS THAT POINT TO A PRICING OR PLANS PAGE



Only 1.0% of Google's top-10 pages ever show up in a ChatGPT answer.

91%
of bottom-funnel queries get a ChatGPT link

8%
of top-funnel queries do

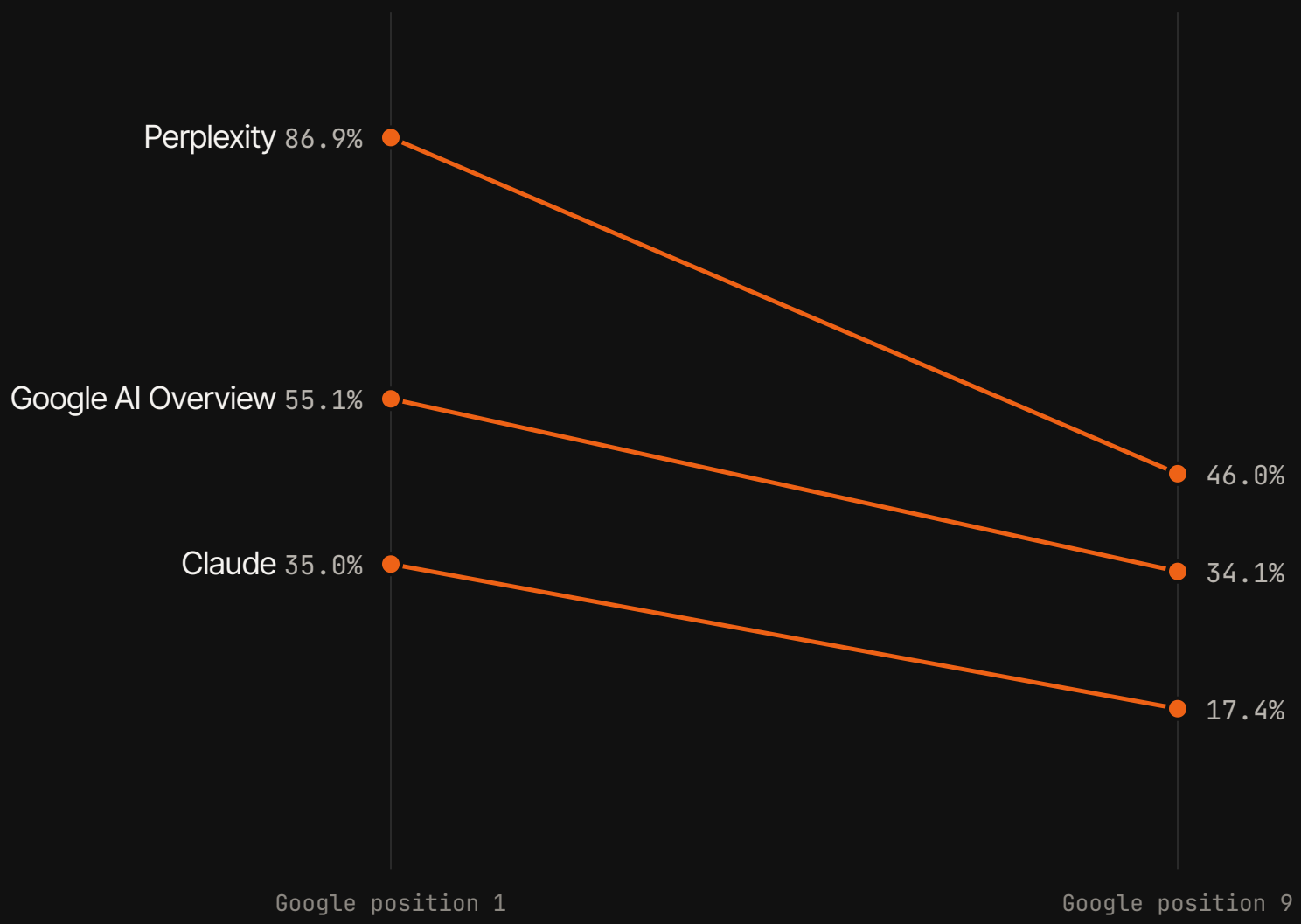
34.5%
Claude tilts the other way: top-10 pages quoted on informational queries, vs 21.0% on transactional

→ On ChatGPT, your pricing page is the citable asset for commercial queries. Your blog barely appears.

FINDING 07 · RANK

Ranking higher helps in every engine. No rank is safe in all of them.

CITATION RATE OF TOP-10 PAGES BY GOOGLE POSITION



87%
chance Perplexity cites the #1 result

35%
chance Claude cites the same #1 result

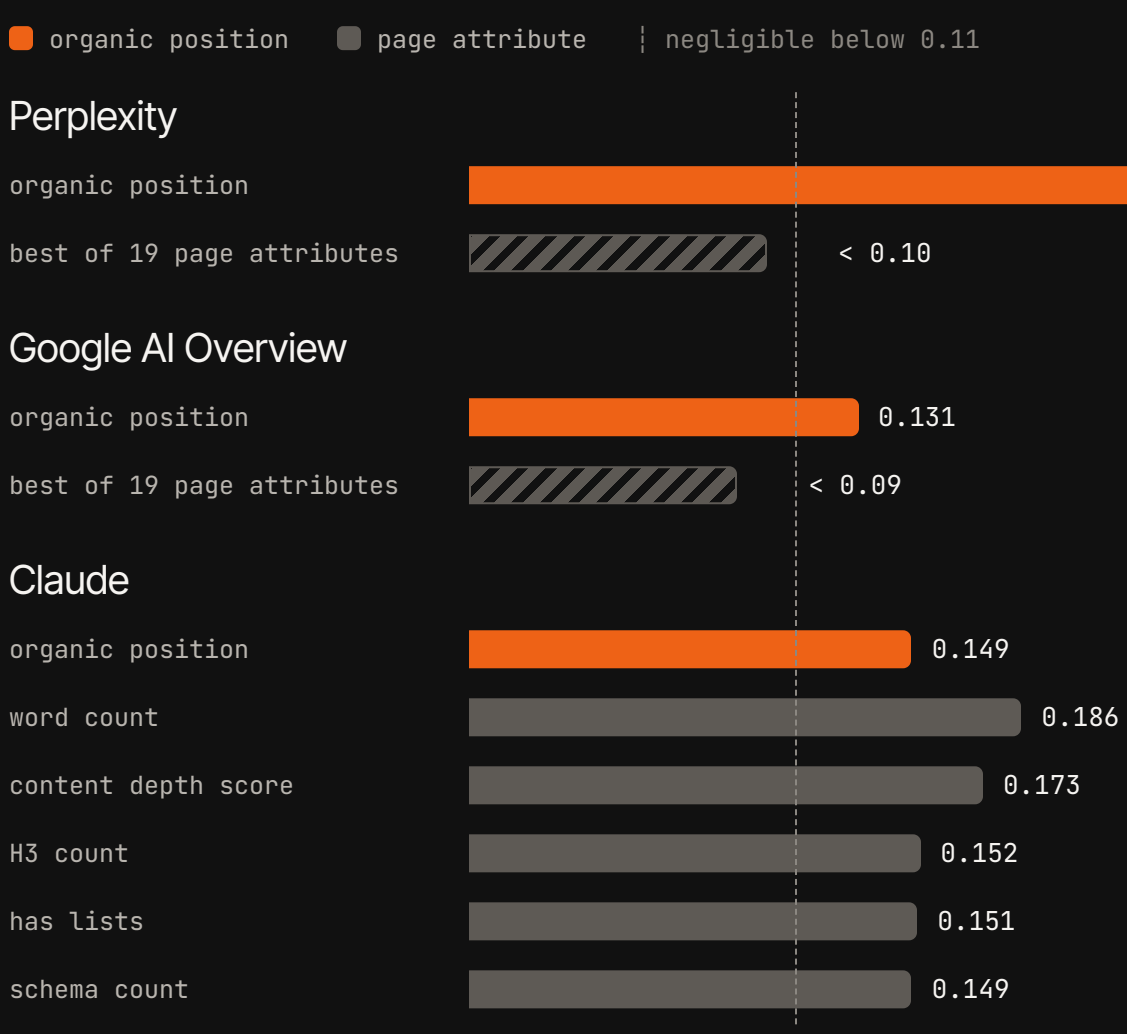
1.6–1.9×
advantage of position 1 over position 9, every engine

→ Rank is the only lever that transfers across engines. It is also a weak one.

FINDING 08 · PAGE ATTRIBUTES

19 page attributes tested.
None beat rank in Perplexity or Google.

EFFECT SIZE ON CITED VS NOT CITED · |CLIFF'S δ| · 6,881 RANKING PAGES



78 vs 76
median DR, pages Perplexity cited vs skipped

76 vs 78
same for Claude, pointing the wrong way

+0.6–4.1
points over base rate, full model with all 19 attributes

→ Among ranking pages there is no content checklist for Perplexity or Google. Claude is the one engine that rewards depth.

FINDING 09 · FORMATS

Definition pages travel everywhere. Pricing pages flip.

SHARE OF RANKING PAGES CITED, BY FORMAT

	Perplexity	Claude	AI Overview
Definition 611 pages	68.1%	39.1%	53.4%
Comparison 615 pages	73.8%	29.6%	55.1%
How-to 377 pages	66.6%	30.0%	46.4%
Pricing 375 pages	77.1%	34.1%	38.1%
Listicle 3,380 pages	71.7%	24.6%	44.0%
General 1,510 pages	69.5%	13.8%	40.7%

Definition is the only format in the top two for all three citing engines.

Pricing is Perplexity's most-cited format (77.1%) and AI Overview's least-cited (38.1%).

→ Write the definitional page first. Decide on pricing pages engine by engine.

THE PLAYBOOK

Stop optimising for "AI". Optimise per engine.

Perplexity

THE RANK-FOLLOWER

Rank top 3 and it cites you 77–87% of the time.

Reddit is its #1 domain. Community content pays here.

Google AI Overview

RANK, THEN FORMAT

Rank is still its strongest signal.

Definition and comparison pages get cited 53–55% of the time.

Claude

DEPTH OVER FORUMS

Depth, length and structure are its only content signals.

0 forum pages quoted. Invest in your own deep pages.

ChatGPT

A PRODUCT SURFACE

91% of commercial queries get links, 8% of informational.

A third of its links go to pricing pages.

Gemini

NAMED, NOT CITED

No visible links in our capture.

Being named in the answer is the whole game.

Across all of them

Track each engine separately.
Measure being **named**, not being cited.

LIMITATIONS · WHAT'S NEXT

What this can and can't tell you.

LIMITS

API with web search, not the consumer apps. Absolute levels are API-side.

One run per query, one capture date (3 Aug 2026). Run-to-run variance isn't separated.

Gemini's grounding metadata wasn't captured. Gemini is scored on vendor mentions only.

Page attributes exist only for pages Google shows, about a quarter of the cited pool.

Vendor matching uses 154 curated brands, so it misses vendors outside the list.

NEXT

The 74%.

What the cited pages outside Google actually are.

Study designed and run by **Akilan**, Slate research.
Written up by **Shiyam Sunder**.

Follow for the next Citation Lab drop.

THREE NUMBERS TO REMEMBER

0.09%
of citations shared by all three engines

0
Reddit citations from ChatGPT and Claude

0.307
effect of rank in Perplexity. No page attribute beat 0.10